

How satisfied are you with the service?



Yes, I would buy from this company again



rather than repair her UMAX scanner, she says, "Its light needed to be changed and the service centre said it would be less expensive to give it up and buy a newer USB scanner." Nikhil Joshi a multimedia co-ordinator, says, "No and never to UMAX even if it is offered free. Worst company, worst product and horrible service support."

Small surprise that UMAX scored the lowest on the Reliability Index in our consumer survey.

The quality of glass used in BenQ scanners was a source of complaint. Kreisler Drego mentioned that, "the glass used in the BenQ scanners are of a very poor quality making it difficult for the cathode lamp to shed light on the image being scanned. Each service was worse than the previous, especially as far as replacement of the glass was concerned." BenQ scored the lowest on the Service Index.

MOST RELIABLE SCANNER: Canon RUNNER-UP: HP
MOST SATISFACTORY SERVICE: Canon RUNNER-UP: HP

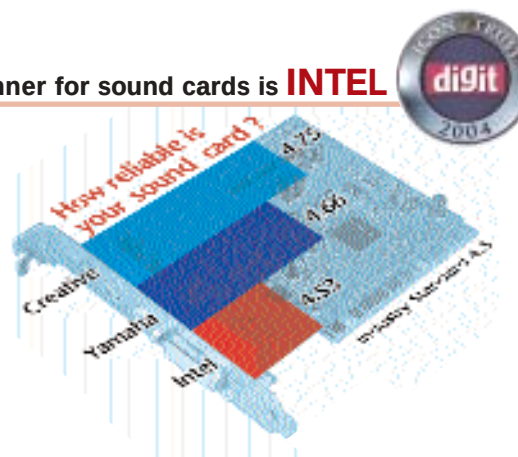
Sound Cards

As a company, Creative equals sound cards. Its products have engineered sound on the PC right from the days of the mono-coloured DOS prompt, up to the kaleidoscopic million-coloured screens of today. And in keeping up with the big-bang in colours, the company has enabled an explosion in sound from the mono-channels of bygone to the 7-channel band that plays on a PC near you. Remember however, a shadier aspect of those days—the hunt for the right driver, the tweaking with the DMAs and the IRQs, the fiddling with those tiny jumpers to get the little buggers to sing a song of 16-bit. A walk through this section should

bring those memories rushing back. Things are not the same of course, but users are humming a familiar tune of software woes, driver problems and hardware conflicts...

To begin with, the survey confirmed the absolute dominance of Creative products in the field of soundcards. Of a healthy 296 that responded under this category, an overwhelming 225 had Creative solutions nestled within their systems. Yamaha came a distant second with 40, while Intel huffed and puffed with only 19 entries. Yamaha cards were, not surprisingly, the oldest of the bunch, followed by Creative. Note that Intel here represents the onboard solution

Winner for sound cards is **INTEL**



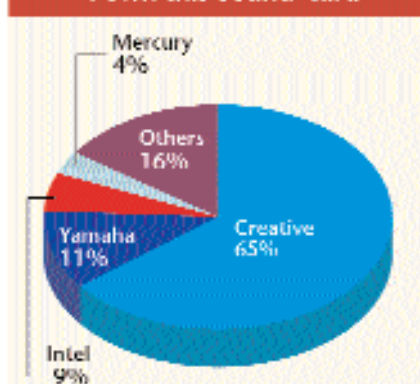
when it comes to sound cards..." Creative won as far as reliability of products was concerned, but niggling hardware problems experienced by a percentage of respondents, along with the fact that the problem was seldom unsolved, meant that the company scored the lowest in service. So Yamaha came in second and Intel stole the top.

Hardware compatibility problems, ranging from "compatibility issues with my new MSI KT6 Delta motherboard and Pinnacle Studio 8 software", to, "it interferes with the TV reception if I have a TV-tuner card on the motherboard", coupled with driver woes "they should get some real coders to make their drivers, their

Bhagwan in the field

Rahul Mundra, on Creative sound cards
Gujarat

I own this sound card



found on motherboards, not a stand-alone card. With that in mind, it comes as no surprise to find Intel solutions requiring the least service within a two-year period. Yamaha cards did not fare too well in this aspect, coming in at the third place by quite a margin.

Creative scored highly on the Reliability Index, a fact corroborated by readers such as long-time user Prosenjit Sarkar from Kolkatta, "My old PC has a Creative Sound Blaster Live, and it has been running for over seven years now. I have a very high opinion of Creative products

Intel solutions were not only **reliable**, problems related to them were also solved the most **quickly**